BOB MARLEY *and* SELASSIE

Within the Rastafari movement, Haile Selassie is regarded not simply as a political leader, but as the divine incarnation of God Jah and the fulfillment of biblical prophecy.
Through his life, lyrics, performances, and interviews, Bob Marley communicates clearly the central role Selassie plays within Rastafari theology, identity, and political consciousness.

> "I believe in the Bible. The Bible say the King of Kings and the Lord of Lords. Who is that? Haile Selassie."
>
> Rastafari is not a religion. It is a way of life.

"We are going to our Father's land." ~Bob Marley
This reflects the Zion concept Ethiopia as sacred homeland reinforcing Selassie's spiritual and geographic centrality.

Rita Marley stated that during Haile Selassie's 1966 visit to Jamaica, she saw marks in his hands, which she interpreted as the wounds of Christ.
This experience strengthened her belief in Selassie's divinity.
The event deeply influenced Bob Marley's commitment to Rastafari.
It reinforced the Rastafarian view of Selassie as Jah incarnate, not merely a political emperor.

THE THEOLOGICAL AND POLITICAL SIGNIFICANCE OF HAILE SELASSIE IN RASTAFARI

SELASSIE AS DIVINE KING (JAH INCARNATE)

Rastafari believers interpret Selassie's 1930 coronation where he was titled "King of Kings, Lord of Lords, Conquering Lion of the Tribe of Judah" as fulfillment of Revelation 5:5.

SELASSIE AS VOICE OF JUSTICE AND LIBERATION

WAR 1976

The lyrics are taken almost entirely from a 1963 speech delivered by Haile Selassie at the United Nations.
Marley sings:
"Until the philosophy which holds one race superior and another inferior is finally and permanently discredited and abandoned..."
By directly transforming Selassie's speech into song, Marley elevates him from emperor to prophetic voice.

ETHIOPIA AS ZION

Songs like:
"Exodus"
"Africa Unite"
"Iron Lion Zion"
Reference Africa as redemption and return.
"Iron Lion Zion" explicitly refers to Selassie as:

- The Lion of Judah
- A conquering spiritual ruler

MARLEY'S PERSONAL IDENTIFICATION WITH SELASSIE

NOVEMBER 4,1980

Marley was not simply using Selassie symbolically for marketing.
He:

- Was baptized into the Ethiopian Orthodox Church before his death
- Wore imagery associated with Selassie
- Publicly defended Rastafari beliefs despite criticism